

Ursus arctos

Brown bear



Length 5–9ft (1.5–2.8 m)
Tail 2¼–8¼in (6–21 cm)
Weight 175–1,213 kg (80–550 lb)
Location N. and N.W. North America, N. Europe, Asia
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



The brown bear enjoys the widest distribution of all bear species and varies widely in size depending on its food and habitat. Large areas of open wilderness are important to its survival, which explains why populations can be found in isolated areas such as parts of Alaska and the Yukon, while habitat destruction in the rest of North America and Europe has seen a drastic reduction in its numbers there. The brown bear's distinctive features are its shoulder hump of muscle, and long claws that help it to dig for roots and bulbs. It can stand upright on its hind paws in order to identify a threat or a food source. Although mainly herbivorous, brown bears will readily eat meat when it is available. To avoid winter food shortage, they can den up in dugouts in hillsides, or in brush, for as long as 6 months, during which period the female also gives birth to her cubs. The lifespan of the brown bear is about 25 years in the wild and longer in captivity.

concave profile

powerful limbs

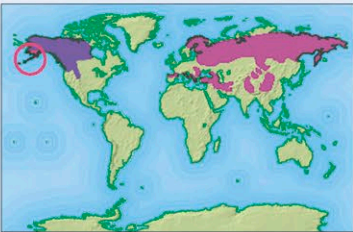
coat usually dark brown, but varies from blonde to black

long, nonretractable front claws

prominent shoulder hump

dense coat

BROWN BEAR SUBSPECIES



■ KODIAK ■ GRIZZLY ■ EURASIAN

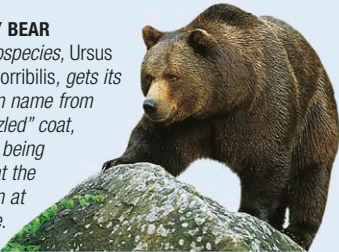
KODIAK BEAR

Weighing up to 1,720 lb (780 kg), the impressive Kodiak bear, *Ursus arctos middendorfi*, is the largest of the subspecies.



GRIZZLY BEAR

This subspecies, *Ursus arctos horribilis*, gets its common name from its "grizzled" coat, the hair being lighter at the tips than at the base.



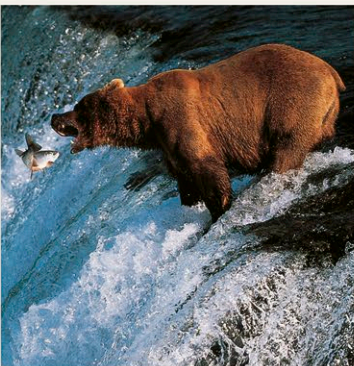
EURASIAN BROWN BEAR

This bear, *Ursus arctos arctos*, is the smallest member of the species. Rapid loss of habitat has now restricted it to small pockets of mountain woodland.



SALMON HARVEST

Brown bears are comfortable in water and may wait for hours at waterfalls or in the shallows of a stream ready to dive on their prey. For some populations of brown bears, salmon forms a vital source of protein in the bear's diet. These populations are usually the largest of the species. As spawning salmon swim upstream, the brown bear pounces, delivering a crushing bite with its powerful jaws or a stunning blow from one of its large, clawed paws. Once caught, the fish rarely escape the bear's grasp.



POWERFUL BUILD

Brown bears are large, powerfully built animals. Although there is little difference in body length between the sexes, males can be up to twice as heavy as females, which have a smaller, lighter frame. Both sexes feed intensively from spring to fall in order to put on weight in preparation for winter sleep.

AGGRESSIVE BEHAVIOR

Due to its power, size, and unpredictable behavior, the brown bear has long been considered a threat to humans and livestock. Grizzly bears evolved in open habitat and may act aggressively when defending themselves, since they have little opportunity to find the safety of any cover. A mother with young cubs is a particularly dangerous animal to encounter. Nevertheless, bears will usually avoid coming into contact with humans.